

Rationality: The Critical Difference

Rationalism, according to the *Oxford American Dictionary*, is a belief that one's opinions or actions should be based on reason and knowledge rather than emotional responses. A rational person thinks clearly, sensibly, and logically.

The first thing to understand is that rationality is not the same as intelligence. Smart people can do dumb things. Keith Stanovich, a professor of human development and applied psychology at the University of Toronto, believes that intelligence tests like IQ tests or SAT/ACT exams do a very poor job of measuring rational thought. “It is a mild predictor at best,” he says, “and some rational thinking skills are totally dissociated from intelligence.”³

In his book, *What Intelligence Tests Miss: The Psychology of Rational Thought*, he coined the term *dysrationalia*—the inability to think and behave rationally despite high intelligence. Research in cognitive psychology suggests there are two principal causes of dysrationalia. The first is a processing problem. The second is a content problem. Let's look at them closely, one at a time.

Stanovich believes we humans process poorly. When solving a problem, he says, people have different cognitive mechanisms to choose from. At one end of the thinking spectrum are mechanisms that have great computational power. But this great computational power comes with a cost. It is a slower process of thinking and requires a great deal of concentration. At the opposite end of the thinking spectrum are mechanisms with very little computational power; they require very little concentration and permit quick decisions. “Humans are cognitive misers,” writes Stanovich, “because our basic tendency is to default to the processing mechanisms that require less computational effort, even if they are less accurate.”⁴ In a word, humans are lazy thinkers. They take the easy way out when solving problems; as a result, their solutions are often illogical.

Slow-Moving Ideas